



Chase Xu
Vice President, Realme

Why limited edition phones matter

Realme's VP & CMO explains with the help of Game Of Thrones phone

Mustafa Khan | editor@digit.in

Northern Ireland is not the first place you would expect a smartphone company to host a launch. Yet recently, Realme gathered journalists and content creators from around the world at the home of Game of Thrones. Why? Because they think creating phones is not just about tools, but stories. The occasion was the launch of the Realme 15 Pro Game of Thrones Limited Edition, which is the first phone to roll out with this collaboration. On this Limited Edition phone, you get a few engravings on the back, a customised UI, and a vegan leather back that shifts colour with heat, inspired by Daenerys Targaryen's rise from the ashes.

"We wanted to combine the GOT vibe with our technology," says Chase Xu, Vice President of Realme. "The

inspiration came from Daenerys rising from the ashes. We wanted to recreate that magical scene."

It's not the company's first such experiment. Over the years, Realme has partnered with Naruto, Dragon Ball Z, Coca-Cola, and even Aston Martin F1. But unlike traditional product tie-ins, these are not just marketing gimmicks. Limited-edition phones have become an increasingly strategic tool for smartphone makers.

Exclusivity's major role

Smartphone launches have begun to feel like clockwork: new chip, better cameras, faster charging. Amid this sameness, collaborations like Realme's Game of Thrones edition aim to evoke emotion, rather than playing the same specs and benchmarks game. "The most difficult part," Chase admits,

"was creativity and inspiration. Game of Thrones is a classic, award-winning IP. How do we make that fit into our phone without losing its soul?"

Realme pitted two internal design teams against each other, one focused on industrial design, another on brand expression. Both teams submitted multiple design concepts that were later tested with Game of Thrones fans across different countries. "We actually talked to global fans and experts to see which one would wow people the most," Chase says.

That feedback-driven approach hints at something larger: limited editions are not about selling more units, but about building deeper engagement. The Game of Thrones phone, for instance, is capped at just 5,000 units worldwide. "Some countries asked if they could get more," Chase laughs, "but we had to say no. We want our core fans to feel proud, like owning a limited-edition car or designer jacket."

The business logic of being exclusive

At first glance, limiting production sounds counterintuitive for a company chasing growth. But scarcity has its own kind of marketing power.

"Collaboration editions are not about revenue," Chase explains. "They are about providing irreplaceable value to fans. It's more about emotion, pride, and collectability."

This approach mirrors the fashion and automotive industries, where exclusivity drives desirability. Realme's past collaborations, like the Aston Martin Racing Edition, have proven that emotional connection can draw in audiences who might have never even considered using the brand before. "We met people who bought the phone because they were F1 fans," Chase says. "They had never used Realme before. But after trying it, they became our core fans." ■

Read more on Digit.in:
tinyurl.com/4ecst4hc